Chapter Thirty

The Jokyu War

Between 1203 and 1242,
the emperor challenges the shogunate,
and the shogunate triumphs

In 1203, the new shogun of Japan found himself under house arrest. He was twenty-one, and had been shogun for less than four years.

The shogunate itself was only eleven years old. It had been the masterwork of his father, Yoritomo; and at Yoritomo's death, in 1199, it was still a complicated and delicately balanced creation. Kamakura, the eastern city that served as the shogunate's headquarters, was filled with samurai who had a shot at real political power for the first time. Samurai had wielded plenty of clout in Japan over the previous century, but they had always done so in the service of someone else: a government minister, a clan leader, an ambitious official. Samurai swords could determine the outcome of a war, but the samurai themselves had never ascended high enough in the Japanese bureaucratic hierarchy to decree what issues were worth fighting over.[1]

Yoritomo, himself a soldier, had spent much of his life in exile, far from the courts of influence. He had been an outcast with no political pull, and so he had forged a new path back into the center of the official hierarchy. At the beginning of his rebellion, he had promised the samurai in the east that if they swore an oath of allegiance to him, he would guarantee them the estates, the titles, and the offices that none of them yet owned.[2]

When he made the promise, he possessed none of the things he had sworn to give away; nor would he have them, unless the samurai swore the oath and